

ROUGH CUT | KAVEREE BAMZAI

Restore, Not Remove



In India, we have a tendency to tear down institutions without adequately thinking of what will replace them. As Kapil Sibal scraps CBSE's Class X exams, oddly just seven years after the US tried to ape our examination system with the No Child Left Behind Act, I have a suggestion for him. Mr Minister, please take a moment to consider two institutions that you could build up as schools search for ways to continuously and comprehensively evaluate their children beyond the narrow but necessary paradigm of academic excellence. Both institutions received the utmost support from Jawaharlal Nehru, the leading light of the family that continues to guide your party—the National Cadet Corps, started in 1948, and the National Service Scheme, first mooted by him in 1958 in a letter to chief ministers which said social service should be a prerequisite for graduation. Please consider for a moment the plight of parents and their children and understand why some of them actually welcome a standardised examination. Most of them have to go into PTAs clutching a photograph of their children to jog the teachers' memory. Most of them have to contend with energetic youngsters restricted to one physical education class per week. Most of them face a situation where any talent in art, dance or music is rarely allowed to develop beyond junior school unless the child is a prodigy capable of earning the school laurels.

Worse, the SUPW period, also once a week, is rarely allotted to even the token activities my generation undertook, visits to old age homes and urban slums. And yet, at forum after forum, politicians, suddenly fired up by your vision of a brave new world, speak of the demographic dividend, of the value of creating good citizens. Such good citizens that they would go on UTV

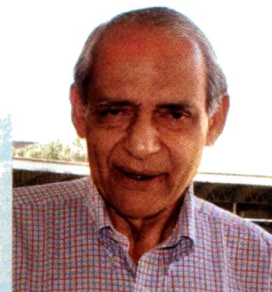
Bindass' *Dadagiri* to look for cheese cubes in a bowl of leeches and eat sauce mixed with human hair. Or go without sleep for 48 hours on Channel V's *Exhausted*. Or feed crocodiles and eat slugs on *MTV Roadies*. These are mostly youngsters straight out of school looking for adventure, and yes, instant fame. Surely they would be better served by the thrill of playing a soldier in the NCC or the outdoor work of the NSS. Surely, they would welcome the opportunity to develop their own portfolio of non-academic achievements upon leaving school, studded with hours of community service and professional internships, burnished by the ability to write term papers and deliver speeches? Who wouldn't if it promises a future where they will be leaders, not followers?



SALUBAH SINGH/www.indiabodyimages.com

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Raj Singh Dungarpur, 73, former BCCI president and a former Ranji cricketer. He was also a former chair-



man of the selection committee and manager of several Indian teams on important overseas tours.

WON: By Vijender Singh, the bronze medal at the Milan World Boxing Championships in the 75-kg class. The Beijing Olympics medallist became the first Indian boxer to win a medal at the World Championships.

DIED: Jogesh Chandra Rout, 84. He was elected to the Orissa Assembly four times and had been the agriculture and cooperation minister in 1976-77.

WON: By Leander Paes and partner Luks Dlouhy (Czech Republic), the US Open Men's Doubles. This was Paes' fifth mens doubles title in a Grand Slam event and his 10th Grand Slam doubles title overall.

